Pakistan. With no natural allies or major funding flows of its own, the ISI presumed the group would be a more pliable proxy than other outfits. This proved an accurate assessment, even after Lashkar leveraged state support to develop its own infrastructure and economic interests in Pakistan. While doing so enabled the group to grow far more powerful domestically than the ISI might have anticipated, this infrastructure provided Lashkar's handlers with leverage over it. Were the group to act too independently of its handlers, they could threaten to shut down its domestic operations and seize its assets. Unlike the Deobandi groups, this infrastructure was specific to Lashkar and so the group did not have a wider support network to fall back on.

The 1993–95 period when the state began escalating its support for Lashkar marked a turning point for the group. Till then its militants had waged jihad on multiple fronts, but thereafter the focus was liberating Indian-administered Kashmir. However, it would be a mistake to view this as merely the result of practical calculation; Lashkar's leaders embraced an umma-oriented ideology, but viewed the Kashmir jihad as the most legitimate one for the group. They argued that because Indian-administered Kashmir was the closest occupied land, it was an Islamic obligation for the group's members to fight there and that this front took precedence over others. The Kashmir jihad was also among the most important because the ratio of occupying forces to the population was one of the highest in the world, and so it was among the largest and most heinous occupations in the Muslim world. Thus, Lashkar cadres were told they were doctrinally obligated to prioritize fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir, though they could volunteer to fight on other fronts and a small number are believed to have gone to Chechnya and the Philippines during the mid-to-late 1990s.[20] The core leadership of the group continued to hold these views after 9/11 according to Lashkar members who outlined these ideological arguments for the author.[21]

Lashkar's leaders also viewed the Kashmir jihad as only the latest chapter in a Hindu-Muslim struggle which has existed ever since the time of the Prophet Muhammad. They argue that Hindus are the worst of the polytheists and that the Prophet Muhammad singled out India as a special target for jihad. 'Whosoever will take part in jihad against India,' Lashkar's Muhammad Ibrahim Salaf has asserted the Prophet declared, 'Allah will set